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Brokerage Account Opening Checklist

Tick each box as you go. Based on the MarketAI Academy lessons on choosing a broker, opening an account and funding it.

1. Choose a broker you can trust

- [ ] The broker accepts residents of my country.
- [ ] I found the broker's exact legal entity name in its client agreement or website footer.
- [ ] I searched that exact name on my regulator's official register, reached through the regulator's own website, not a link from the broker.
- [ ] The register shows the firm is authorised to hold client money and assets.
- [ ] I know which investor compensation scheme, if any, covers this entity, and I read its limits on the scheme's own website.
- [ ] I read who the custodian is and how client cash is held.
- [ ] It offers what I want to buy (for example the ETFs or markets I plan to use).
- [ ] I compared total costs, not headline prices: commissions, currency conversion, custody and withdrawal fees.

> **Walk away if:** the firm is not on the official register; someone contacted you first on social media or a messaging app; you are promised guaranteed or very high returns; you are pressed to deposit quickly or fund with crypto or a personal bank account; withdrawals are "temporarily unavailable" or need a fee first; or the main products are CFDs and leveraged trading.

2. Gather your documents

- [ ] **Proof of identity:** valid passport or national ID (not expired).
- [ ] **Proof of address:** recent utility bill, bank statement or government letter (often within three months).
- [ ] **Tax identification number** from past returns or your tax authority's site.
- [ ] **Bank account in your own name** for deposits and withdrawals.
- [ ] **Mobile number** that can receive two-factor login codes.
- [ ] Clear photos or scans in good light, all four corners visible.

3. Complete the application

- [ ] Created a login with a unique password and turned on two-factor authentication.
- [ ] Chose the account type (individual, joint, or a tax-advantaged account if available).
- [ ] Used the exact name on my ID everywhere, with no spelling differences.
- [ ] Answered the suitability questions honestly. Restrictions on some products are normal for beginners.
- [ ] Verified my identity and uploaded documents.
- [ ] Signed the tax forms. Non-US persons buying US shares usually sign Form W-8BEN; I checked my country of residence on it.
- [ ] Noted that a W-8BEN generally stays valid until the end of the third calendar year after signing, and set a reminder to renew.

- [ ] Completed the CRS self-certification if asked (normal under international account reporting).
- [ ] Read the client agreement and the fee schedule before accepting.

4. Fund the account safely

- [ ] Sending only from a bank account in my own name.
- [ ] Copied the broker's transfer details and payment reference exactly.
- [ ] Made a small test deposit first and waited for it to arrive.
- [ ] Decided where to convert currency (my bank or the broker) after comparing the rate and fees.
- [ ] Did not let my bank convert a wire I meant to send in my home currency.
- [ ] Avoided credit cards for deposits (some issuers treat them as cash advances).
- [ ] Checked the exchange rate I actually got against the mid-market rate.

5. My account record

Broker and legal entity	
Regulator and register number	
Compensation scheme and limit	
Account number	
Account type and base currency	
Date opened	
W-8BEN signed on / renew by	
Deposit route and payment reference	
Where I keep statements	

> Keep this page somewhere safe and offline. Never write your password on it.

Common problems

- [ ] **Document rejected:** re-take it in daylight, all corners visible, with a recent date.
- [ ] **Name mismatch:** use the exact name on your ID across every document.
- [ ] **Country not supported:** choose another broker. Never use a false address.
- [ ] **Deposit returned:** it was probably sent from someone else's account.

Educational material only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Rules and broker terms change; confirm details with your regulator, tax authority or broker. Version: October 2026.